This second case accused Sasi of amassing wealth that was disproportionate to his known sources of income. The rest were accused of helping him amass that wealth.

My feelings for Sasi had seesawed repeatedly. When I got arrested I hated him for landing me in this mess. When the IB tortured me based on Sasi's confession, I was in mood to land a punch on his nose. But now, after coming to Viyyur, I had understood him, and the others, better. After all, we were all victims of a common conspiracy. I might not have agreed to 'confess' under duress, but why should I expect Sasi, Chandra and the others to have such a high endurance level?

According to the ignorant, scheming IB sleuths, Sasi and I had worked in tandem to smuggle out the rocket drawings from ISRO to hand it over to Pakistan through the Maldivian women. Some IB men's fertile imagination had given rise to even such stories where Sasi and I have gone with the Maldivian women to some ISRO facilities and on pleasure trips.

The truth was that Sasi and I started sharing even a joke, mostly at the expense of Chandra, only after being sent to Viyyur prison. Though we worked on the same campus in Trivandrum, we were never close friends.

In fact, our earlier interactions, including the first encounter, were bitter. Our paths crossed first, literally, on way to ISRO's VSSC campus in Trivandrum. I was on my scooter when the driver of a car kept honking from behind, trying to overtake me. Blame it on young age, I went full throttle ahead, not allowing the car to outrun me. On reaching the VSSC gate, I stopped the scooter and stared at the man in the car. We had a little fracas. I did not know who he was, not even the fact that he worked with VSSC.

It was a bit embarrassing when we came face to face the next time at work, but we got over it. Work brought us together briefly, now and then, but friction remained between us. When Satish Dhawan made me the chairman of a committee that would decide on the interchangeability of the segments of SLV-3, Sasi, who was junior to me, but was working in a different department, made a presentation. I found his premise weak, and opposed his suggestion.